Hop and count phonemes

Why we love it

This exercise is all about hearing all of the individual sounds within a word. In addition to helping with reading, this skill will be essential as children learn to write words at the end of Kindergarten and beyond. Help them develop this important skill by using this fun, physical game!

Materials

Sound Cards
Chalk

Instructions

- Draw a hopscotch board on the ground with chalk and add numbers.
  - Start with a board that goes up to 3, and only use sounds cards with words that have 2-3 sounds.
  - Add sound cards with more sounds once your child gets comfortable. Your child may work up to 5 sounds.
  - If indoors, try using tape on the floor.
- Your child can pick a sound card from the deck and say the name of the picture. Then, they will count the number of sounds (phonemes) in the word and hop that number of spaces on the board.
  - For example: If your child picks up the word “sun”, they will sound out the word /s/, /u/, /n/ and identify that it has 3 sounds.
  - Then, they will start hopping! They should say the sounds as they hop (*hop 1* - /s/, *hop 2* - /u/, *hop 3* - /n/).
  - Once they get to the final square, they should repeat the whole word. Once they get to square 3, they will say “sun”.
- Keep taking turns until everyone has had a chance!

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Sound Count Race

Why we love it

Playing this game helps your child get ready to read by listening closely to the sounds in words. When kids break a word into its sounds, they're learning an important skill called phonemic awareness. This helps them figure out new words when they start reading and makes spelling easier, too!

Materials

-Sound Cards
-Sound Count Race Sheet
-Crayons or markers

Instructions

- Start with Sound Cards that have 2-3 sounds.
- Child will have a Sound Count Race Sheet and crayons or markers.
- Shuffle the Sound Cards well before you pick a card.
- Look at the picture and say the word. You may use movements such as tapping fingers to stretch out the sounds in the word.
  - Ex: "Let's say the word: sun." Ask: 'How many sounds?' "/s/.../u/.../n/".
- Players will use the Sound Card Race Sheet to shade in the box that shows how many sounds are in the word.
  - Ex: For sun = 3 sounds → Shade 1 box in the column with number 3.
- Child will pick up a new Sound Card and continue to play until one column has reached the finish line at the top!
  - Ex: "I filled all of the boxes for 3! 3 won!"
- *As your child gets more comfortable, introduce Sound Cards with 4-5 sounds.*
- *May choose to laminate the Sound Count Race board and use dry erase markers for reuse.*

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